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# Colophons and Cultural Biography: Episodes from the Life of *The Ear Picker*

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A white-robed gentleman sits casually in front of a landscape screen idly picking his ear [figure 1]. The activity is intimate and curious. What is the meaning of this gesture, and why should it become a subject of a painting?<sup>1</sup> Over the centuries, these questions about the hand-scroll painting traditionally attributed to the Southern Tang court painter Wang Qihan 王齊翰 (active ca. 960–75), *The Ear Picker* 挑耳圖, also known as *Collating Texts* 勘書圖, have generated lively debate among collectors, viewers, and scholars. In the spirit of these exchanges, this article explores this painting's multiple meanings by adopting the strategy of cultural biography and examining colophons to see how three sets of previous viewers constructed the scroll's significance. To the extent that these viewers concern themselves with the painting's authorship, we will take up issues of authenticity, but that topic will not be our primary focus.<sup>2</sup> Rather our project will be to consider the viewer's share in generating meaning and to draw attention to some of the twenty-seven inscriptions and colophons, by writers famous and obscure, that are part of this extraordinary object.

Although *The Ear Picker* is quite worn, as evident in photographic reproductions, we may still appreciate the image of a large screen painted with a lush, blue-and-green landscape, framing a middle-aged man in a domestic interior. The simple and elegant furnishings include a long, low table supporting a number of objects suggesting learning and art: bundled scrolls, books, and a stringed musical instrument. Wearing a white robe that opens slightly, the man sits at another, smaller table with paper, brushes, and books. He neither reads nor writes, but picks his ear, tilting his head slightly as a servant approaches from the right bringing tea. Unfortunately some of the painting losses obscure the man's expression, but he purportedly closes one eye.<sup>3</sup>

Currently in the collection of the Department of History of Nanjing University, *The Ear Picker* has, as one colophon writer put it, "circulated and delighted many eyes," and some of those delighted audiences have left physical traces of their viewing on the scroll.<sup>4</sup> The painting bears two inscriptions and twenty-three seals, and twenty-six colophons follow. Accompanied by three ostensibly imperial Northern Song seals, the inscriptions that frame

This article began as a chapter of my dissertation written under the supervision of Richard Vinograd. I am grateful to him and to Ellen Laing, Amy McNair, and Ankeny Weitz who read and commented on earlier drafts.

1. Peter Sturman has recently argued that the activity of ear picking is one of the "Four Gratifications." I regret that timing does not permit me to address his findings here. Sturman, "Paintings as Correspondence: Deciphering Su Shi, Wang Gong, and Wang Shen"; paper presented at the conference on "Founding Paradigms: The Art and Culture of the Northern Song Dynasty, Taipei, February 5–8, 2007.

2. An extensive discussion of attribution may be found in De-nin D. Lee, "Lives of Handscroll Paintings from the Southern Tang Dynasty, 937–975" (Ph.D. diss., Stanford Univ.,) 136–48.

3. Han Ge 涵閣, "Wudai Wang Qihan Kanshu tu" 五代王齊翰勘書圖, *Wenwu* 文物 1960.10: 61; Ma Hongzeng 馬鴻曾, *Wang Qihan* 王齊翰 (Shanghai: Renmin meishu, 1961).

4. This comment is made in the poetic colophon written by Yongcheng 永城, fourth son of the Qianlong (r. 1736–95) emperor.

FIG. 1. Wang Qihan, attrib., *The Ear Picker*.

the image are patently forged, poor imitations of the slender-gold calligraphy of Song Emperor Huizong 徽宗 (r. 1101–25). They give the alternate title, “Collating Texts,” and praise the “marvelous brush of Wang Qihan” 王齊翰妙筆. The seal of the Southern Tang dynasty (937–975), “Jianye wenfang zhi yin” 健業文房之印, purports to be the earliest marking; however, that remains unverifiable. Numerous other seals and the twenty-six colophons, dating from 1091 through 1911 and appended to the painting, make the scroll much longer than its official dimensions (28.4 × 65.7 cm) and permit an approximate reconstruction of its provenance [figure 2]. The precise origins of the painting remain obscure, but we may be more confident that the Northern Song scholar-official Wang Gong 王鞏 (1048–1104) once owned it. Later colophons confirm other collectors, including a certain Li Shuxia 李叔夏 of the Jin dynasty, An Guipo 安桂坡 (mid- to late 16th c.?) and his descendant An Wujiu 安無咎 (ca. early 17th c.), and the Qing imperial prince and grandson of the Qianlong emperor (r. 1736–95), Miande 綿德.<sup>5</sup> Strong external evidence indicates that the Manchu official Duanfang 端方 (1861–1911) possessed *The Ear Picker* before it came into the hands of the Canadian-American sinologist John C. Ferguson (1866–1945), who later donated it along with much of his Chinese art collection to Nanjing University.

In addition to providing evidence regarding provenance, the many colophons provide clues to understanding the meaning of the ear picker. The three earliest colophons figured in Peter Sturman’s study of portraiture by Northern Song intellectuals.<sup>6</sup> Wu Hung examined these same colophons in the context of his research on the peculiarities of the handscroll

5. Huang Yuyu 黃玉瑜 has attempted the most comprehensive reconstruction of the extant scroll’s provenance of sixteen individual collectors, beginning with Southern Tang emperor Li Yu 李煜 (r. 961–75), in “Wang Qihan hui Tiao’-er tu shoucang shimo kao” 王齊翰繪挑耳圖收藏始末考, *Nanjing daxue xuebao* 南京大學學報 1962.4: 47–52. In addition to evidence on the scroll itself, records dating to the Ming and Qing dynasties mention a scroll called “The Ear Picker” or “Collating Texts.” See Fu Kaisen 馮開森 (John Ferguson), *Lidai zhulu huamu* 歷代著錄畫目, vol. 1 (Yangzhou: Jiangsu guanglu guji, 1994), 119–22. A related extant painting may be found in the Freer Gallery, Washington, D.C. See Thomas Lawton, *Chinese Figure Painting* (Washington, D.C.: Freer Gallery of Art, 1973), 78–80.

6. Peter C. Sturman, “In the Realm of Naturalness: Problems of Self-Imaging by the Northern Sung Literati,” in *Arts of the Sung and Yuan*, ed. Maxwell K. Hearn and Judith G. Smith (New York: Department of Asian Art, Metropolitan Museum of Art, 1996), 165–85.

FIG. 2. Schematic diagram of colophons (not to scale).

format. He sees colophons as “textual enclosures,” which mediate the viewer’s understanding of imagery.<sup>7</sup> Although these treatments of *The Ear Picker* contribute to our understanding, neither of them deals with the presence of the twenty-three colophons following those of the Northern Song period. In the present study I shall analyze the colophons in three sets—those from the Northern Song period, from the Jin and Ming dynasties, and from the high Qing period—and shall discuss their allusions in order to understand how different viewers have responded to the painting at different times. We shall find that Song-dynasty poet-politicians saw the painting as political metaphor; Jin and Ming dynasty men treated it as a commodity; and Qing imperial princes and officials raised questions of connoisseurship and religious enlightenment.

#### NORTHERN SONG SECRETS?

Since this inquiry is based on the texts physically appended to the painting, our analysis begins in the late Northern Song period (960–1127) when a group of men brought personal, political matters to bear on *The Ear Picker*. A complicated narrative engaging and elaborating the imagery of *The Ear Picker* emerges in the three colophons written by Su Che 蘇轍 (1039–1112); Su Che’s famous older brother, the accomplished statesman and literatus Su Shi 蘇軾 (1037–1101); and their friend, the painter and imperial son-in-law Wang Shen 王詵 (ca. 1048–after 1104).<sup>8</sup> This episode has previously been examined by Peter Sturman

7. Wu Hung, *The Double Screen: Medium and Representation in Chinese Painting* (Chicago: Univ. of Chicago Press, 1996).

8. For an extensive study of how Northern Song intellectuals embedded political commentary in their art, see Alfreda Murck, *Poetry and Painting in Song China: The Subtle Art of Dissent* (Cambridge, Mass.: Council on East Asian Studies, Harvard Univ., 2000).

FIG. 3. Colophons by Su Che, Su Shi, Wang Shen, and Shi Gongyi.

as the basis for a new attribution and an example of the portraiture of naturalness. Here, it serves primarily as a point of departure from which to measure shifts in audience reception.

On February 1, 1091, Su Che inscribed the following colophon [figure 3].

The feather-clothed gentleman leans on his bed, picking his ear. With emptied breast, he can be especially happy! At the moment, Dingguo [Wang Gong], has no matters [to deal with] and can be like this. But he is about to gallop around and will not return [to this repose]. On the tenth day of the first lunar month, sixth year of Yuanyou [February 1, 1091] seen by Ziyou [Su Che].<sup>9</sup>

羽衣丈夫据床剔耳，胸中蕭然殊可喜也。定國方無事可以為此，但行將馳驅不復爾耳。元祐六年正月初十日子由觀。

Obvious discrepancies exist between Su Che's text and the image in *The Ear Picker*: Su describes a man dressed in feather garb leaning on a bed, whereas the figure wears a white robe and sits on a chair.<sup>10</sup> But, in both colophon and painting, the figure picks his ear, giving some basis for their juxtaposition. Su Che's unnamed figure is free from material desires, unencumbered with worldly responsibilities, and consequently enjoys an enviable state of happiness. By comparison, his friend Wang Gong 王鞏 (1048–1104) faces a future altogether different from that exemplified by the ear picker. As Sturman has previously explained, Wang Gong's present idleness was a consequence of his indictment in the Crow Terrace Poetry Case of 1079, in which the main defendant Su Shi stood accused of composing and disseminating treasonous lyrics that opposed the reforms led by Wang Anshi 王安石 (1021–86).<sup>11</sup> A later shift in politics signaled by the ascension of Emperor Zhezong 哲宗 (r. 1086–1100) led to Wang Gong's recall to the capital. Su Che's colophon of 1091 coincides with the time of Wang's rehabilitation. Su Che does not write that the figure in the painting is Wang Gong, but that, at the moment, Wang Gong is *like* the figure. Wang Gong will soon be "galloping around," but for now, he enjoys an "emptied breast."

9. Previous translations of this colophon by Peter Sturman and Wu Hung have informed my own. See Sturman, "In the Realm of Naturalness," 173–74; and Wu, *The Double Screen*, 147.

10. Ma Hongzeng believes the discrepancies indicate that Su Che originally wrote his colophon for a different painting and only later did it become attached to *Collated Texts*. See his *Wang Qihan* (Shanghai: Renmin meishu, 1962), 15–17. Alternatively, Peter Sturman grants Su Che the poetic license to give the ear picker a figurative feather robe and to imagine him leaning on a bed, in order to achieve a stronger association with Daoist ideals. See his "In the Realm of Naturalness," 174–75.

11. For more, see Charles Hartman, "Poetry and Politics in 1079: The Crow Terrace Poetry Case of Su Shih," *Chinese Literature, Essays, Articles, Reviews* 12 (1990): 15–44.

Su Che's statement identifying the figure with (not *as*) Wang Gong may be read against later colophons. Several months after Su Che's initial colophon, his brother, Su Shi, wrote the following [figure 3]:

In the past, Wang Jinqing [Shen] suffered a sudden attack of deafness. He could not endure it and thus sought a cure from me. I answered saying: "You, Sir, are the descendant of a military general.<sup>12</sup> Were your head severed or your breast pierced, there would be no regret. So, are these two ears of such use that you cannot bear to part with them? [I grant you] a three-day limit for your illness to pass. If it does not, cut off and take my ears. Alarmed, Jinqing suddenly understood. In three days the illness was cured. He praised me, saying:

The old ninny's [punning on Su Dongpo] heart is anxious and [you] repeatedly exhorted me; [Your] difficult nature only allowed me a three-day limit.

My ear is already [well], so you need not cut yours;

And so, I am pleased that for our two families things have turned out well.

Today I see *The Ear-picker* that Dingguo [Wang Gong] owns, which he says he received from Jinqing. I learned about this matter in [our] casual conversation. On the second day of the sixth lunar month, sixth year of Yuanyou [June 21, 1091], written by [Su] Shi.<sup>13</sup>

王晉卿嘗暴得耳聾，意不能堪求方於僕，僕答之云，君是將種，斷頭穴胸當無所惜，兩耳堪作底用割，捨不得，限三日疾去，不去，割取我耳。晉卿灑然而悟。三日病良已，以頌示僕云：老婆心急頻相勸，惟難只得三日限。我耳已較君不割，且喜兩家摠平善。今見定國所藏挑耳圖，云得之晉卿。聊識此事。元祐六年六月二日，軾書。

Besides acknowledging Wang Gong's ownership of the painting, Su Shi clarifies the context for both his and his brother's writing—Wang Gong has requested the colophons from his close friends. Responding to this request, Su Che had the painting's owner in mind when composing his colophon. Su Shi deliberately chose an alternative interpretation associating the image with a past incident involving not Wang Gong, but Wang Shen. Inspired by the gesture of the man picking his ear, Su Shi is reminded of Wang Shen and launches into a narrative recollection. To Su Shi's credit, he transcribes Wang Shen's poem into the colophon. Wang Shen begins by cleverly punning on his friend's studio-name ("old ninny" 老婆, *laopo* for "East Slope" 東坡, *dongpo*), effectively characterizing him as an impatient old biddy. In the second couplet, Wang Shen assures his anxious friend that his ear has healed and the threatened organ donation would be unnecessary. Having recovered from both deafness and Su Shi's alarming reprimand, Wang Shen graciously expresses his delight that they and their families are well.

That Su Che should identify the figure with Wang Gong, while Su Shi thinks of Wang Shen, makes the point that the iconography of the ear-picking figure was at that time fluid and subject to the interests of the viewer. It is nevertheless possible that the image functioned as a potent symbol loaded with conventional meaning and traditional associations, in which case these Northern Song viewers may have registered those meanings but chose not to speak openly about them. We will explore this possibility after examining the third and last of the eleventh-century colophons, written by Wang Shen.

Wang Shen writes a rejoinder to Su Shi in a poetic colophon [figure 3].

|       |                                                   |
|-------|---------------------------------------------------|
| 聞諸懿敏子 | I hear that the son of Yimin [Wang Su]            |
| 近得三絕圖 | Recently acquired a "three perfections" painting: |
| 彩翠江南屏 | Brightly colored—a Jiangnan screen,               |
| 我詩老泉書 | My poem, and Laoquan's [Su Xun's] calligraphy.    |

12. Wang Shen's military ancestor is Wang Quanbin 王全斌, *Song shi* (Beijing: Zhonghua, 1977), 255.8919–24.

13. Previous translations of this colophon by Thomas Lawton and Peter Sturman have informed mine. See Lawton, *Chinese Figure Painting*, 79; and Sturman, "In the Realm of Naturalness," 174.



|         |                                                                  |
|---------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 攜夾試開卷   | He brings it here and I unroll the scroll,                       |
| 昨夢真遽遽   | Yesterday's dream—I am startled awake.                           |
| 病忘固不惡   | The illness is forgotten and certainly there was no harm (done); |
| 得聵欣如愚   | Becoming deaf can be enjoyed—like being ignorant.                |
| 煩君強療理   | I annoyed you by forcing you to work on a cure,                  |
| 竅鑿從此始   | The drilling of holes began with this.                           |
| 妙語本無跡   | The roots of profound remarks have no traces;                    |
| 百年誰復識   | In a hundred years who will understand again?                    |
| 一夜東風入柳條 | One night the east wind will blow through the willows,           |
| 可憐漏泄春消息 | Worth cherishing, out will leak the news of spring.              |
| 晉卿      | Jinqing [Wang Shen] <sup>14</sup>                                |

Wang Shen begins by describing the handscroll and relating the circumstances for his colophon. The handscroll had recently come into the collection of the “son of Yimin,” that is Wang Gong, whose father, Wang Su 王肅 (1007–1073), was posthumously given the name Yimin. Next, Wang Shen refers to his friend’s new acquisition as a “three perfections painting,” an artwork combining poetry, calligraphy, and painting. The poetry, transcribed by Su Shi, he acknowledges as his own. The calligraphy he attributes literally to Su Shi and Su Che’s father, Su Xun 蘇洵 (1009–1066), whose *hao* was Laoquan. This attribution raises questions. Both colophons by Su Che and Su Shi are dated to the year 1091, well after their father’s death in 1066. If Wang Gong only “recently acquired” the handscroll, then it would have been impossible for Wang Gong to have asked Su Xun for a colophon. Could it be possible that Wang Gong acquired an old handscroll that already had some writing by Su Xun appended to it? In the handscroll’s current condition, there is no colophon by Su Xun, and we would have to conclude that it was later removed. If this were the case, then Wang Shen overlooks the calligraphy by Su Che and Su Shi in his inventory of the three perfections. Another explanation is that Wang Shen intended “Laoquan” to refer to Su Che and Su Shi. While it may seem unusual to use the father’s name to denote the sons, in the context of these colophons, the usage could be part of a pattern. Earlier, Su Shi made reference to Wang’s Shen’s famous military ancestor. Perhaps Wang Shen found the invocation of ancestors amusing or significant, and he echoes Su Shi’s reference by naming Wang Gong as “son of Yimin” and by using “Laoquan’s calligraphy” to cite the colophons of both Su Che and Su Shi. The final element of the “three perfections” is the screen painting, a brightly colored landscape representing the geography of Jiangnan, the area of the lower Yangzi River valley. Unlike in the cases of poem and calligraphy, no one receives credit for the screen painting.

Wang Shen continues his poem, describing how in the process of unrolling the scroll he is “startled awake” by “yesterday’s dream,” likely the memory of the incident of deafness about which Su Shi chided him. The shock he experiences in remembering echoes his response when Su Shi threatened to cut off his ears. Of course, Wang now admits, there is “certainly no distress,” since he had long forgotten about it. But, he adds, “deafness can be enjoyed—like being ignorant.” He does not deny his former complaints, but he offers the view that not being able to hear has its advantages. Deafness, like ignorance, implies a state of limited knowledge and therefore a reduction or elimination of potentially bothersome news and information. In other words, deafness only seems a disability, like the supposed “ignorance” of Confucius’s favorite student, Yan Hui 顏回 (see *Analects* 2/9). Earlier, Wang Shen was

14. I have consulted translations by Sturman, “In the Realm of Naturalness,” 174; and by Wu, *The Double Screen*, 148.

reluctant to embrace deafness, but later he sees his request for a cure as misguided, for he compares it to the “drilling of holes,” as in the classic case of Hundun.<sup>15</sup> As recounted in *Zhuangzi* 莊子, Hundun, or Chaos, lacked the appropriate openings for the senses—tasting (one mouth), smelling (two nostrils), seeing (two eyes), and hearing (two ears). So that he might gain these human senses, holes were drilled into his body. The result was disastrous: after seven days, he died. Perhaps, Wang implies, he may have been better off a little hard of hearing. The last four lines of Wang’s poem are less focused on the handscroll and the memories stirred by its imagery. He speaks of “profound remarks [that] have no traces,” which a century henceforth may no longer be decipherable.

These cryptic comments along with the common involvement of all persons associated with the handscroll—Wang Gong, Su Che, Su Shi, and Wang Shen—in the Crow Terrace Poetry Case of 1079 led Sturman to the conclusion that the colophons by Su Shi and Wang Shen do not simply narrate an incident of aural health but allude to specific political events and reveal that the figure of the ear picker and the trope of deafness are symbols of political ineptitude and dissension. He furthermore claims that *The Ear Picker* is not an image of an anonymous Southern Tang scholar by Wang Qihan but a portrait of Wang Gong by Wang Shen, and that the composition of *The Ear Picker*, incorporating the landscape screen and the figure of the ear picker seated before it, offers a specific solution to the problem of portraiture for the Northern Song literati.<sup>16</sup> Rather than rehearse the entirety of Sturman’s complex argument and reconstruction of the handscroll’s creation and initial reception, I shall focus on how to understand the trope of deafness and the last lines of Wang Shen’s poetic colophon. To reveal the hidden, symbolic meaning of deafness and the ear picker, we turn, as Sturman did, to a poem written in 1079 during the trial by Su Shi to Qin Guan 秦觀 (1048–1100), yet another friend named in the Crow Terrace Poetry Case.<sup>17</sup> Su Shi’s poem, “Rhyming Qin Guan’s ‘Jesting Deafness’” 次韻秦太虛見戲耳聾, is translated below.<sup>18</sup>

Sir, have you not heard  
Of the poet [Meng Jiao 孟郊 (751–814)] who borrowed a cart but had nothing to move?  
He had but a single coin left, hardly enough to live on.  
In my late years, I become like the old man, Du Ling [Du Fu 杜甫 (712–70)];  
Although my right arm is all right, my ear has gone deaf already.  
Others take ants on the move for the fighting of bulls;<sup>19</sup>  
My own sense of wind and thunder is more like a sigh.  
I hear that when this world is swept away, human roots will be empty;<sup>20</sup>  
[I have] no need to rest [my head] in the clear flowing stream.<sup>21</sup>  
When the great Way was first scattered, Hundun was lost,  
The six [human] senses competed amongst each other for hegemony:  
Eyesight is blurry, [a feeling of] dizziness, and drunkenness,  
Pouring forth of voice cannot cease, and poems incur debt.  
Sir, you know that the five senses are all thieves;  
In one’s life, when there is illness, one can then be cured [of sensory desires, and thus attain enlightenment].

15. Burton Watson, trans., *Chuang Tzu* (New York: Columbia Univ. Press, 1968), 97.

16. Sturman, “In the Realm of Naturalness,” 165–85.

17. *Ibid.*, 175.

18. *Su Shi shiji*, 18.950–51.

19. Yin Zhongkan’s 殷仲堪 father thought the sound of ants crossing beneath his bed to be the din of bulls fighting. See *Jinshu* 晉書 (Beijing: Zhonghua, 1974).

20. “Human roots” are the senses: seeing, hearing, smelling, tasting, touching.

21. The ancient hermit Xu You 許由 is said to have rinsed his ear in a stream after listening to the sage-king Yao’s invitation to cede the kingdom to him.



But I am afraid that in the end I shall not be able to get over it,  
 [Even though I am] Not seeing, not hearing; still, obstacles [preventing enlightenment] remain.  
 Today, Sir, you suspect that I deliberately feign deafness,  
 You purposely made a rousing poem to ridicule me to the extreme  
 Be aware of [the case of the person whose] forehead itched and out came a third ear,<sup>22</sup>  
 Do not allow your brush to run as wild as wind and rain.

The poem describes a situation in which Su Shi occupies the position of Wang Shen (the person with an ear problem), and Qin Guan plays the role of Su Shi (the friend who writes a “rousing poem to ridicule”). But it is apparent that the poem’s subject is not deafness but the frustrating political conditions that Su Shi confronts. By asserting that “pouring forth of voice cannot cease, and poems incur debt,” Su Shi reminds Qin Guan of the near fatal cost of his inability to stem his poetic output in the Crow Terrace Poetry Case.

In much of this poem, written during the court trial, Su Shi develops a metaphor involving deafness and political noise. In contrast to Yin Zhongkan’s father, whose overly sensitive ears magnified the sound of ants marching to the din of bulls fighting, Su Shi is determined to ignore the political noise, which he likens to natural sounds of “wind and thunder.” Their volume is not a din, but “more like a sigh.” Better still, he sees his hardness of hearing as potentially advantageous. As when Wang Shen writes “becoming deaf can be enjoyed—like being ignorant,” Su Shi’s hardness of hearing is a welcome state. Both men see the healthy functioning of this sensory faculty as the problem and the absence of hearing as a solution. Preceding his statement on illness and cures, Su Shi reminds Qin Guan, “Sir, you know that the five senses are all thieves,” reinforcing the idea that being able to hear is the problem. In making this statement, Su Shi introduces an element of Buddhist thought. In the *Surangama Sutra*, a favorite text of Su Shi, the Buddha warns his disciple Ananda, “But your eyes, ears, nose and tongue as well as your body and mind, are the six decoys which a thief uses to steal the treasures of your house.”<sup>23</sup> The “cure” of which Su Shi speaks, then, must be an enlightened state, in which he would be free of the deceptions and desires to which the senses give rise. From this point of view, deafness is a welcome condition. Yet, despite his deaf ear, Su Shi is not sanguine about his condition. He is “afraid that in the end [he] shall not be able to get over it,” and even though he is “not seeing” and “not hearing, still, obstacles remain.”

The figure in the painting shuts one eye while picking at one ear in concert with Su Shi’s self-professed inability to see and to hear. Pointing to that figure, Sturman asserts that “[t]he ear picker attempts to clean his ear, bore a hole, unplug it, cure this deafness and get smart!”<sup>24</sup> But Su Shi’s poem seems to suggest the opposite problem, that although he has the benefit of dulled senses, he fears he still will not be able to wrest himself from the affairs of this world. An attempt to bore a hole and clean out his ear would only exacerbate the problem. Or worse, it might cause the kind of injury suffered by Hundun who is mentioned in the middle of the poem. The drilling of holes into his body for the purpose of producing sensory capacities led instead to his demise. Pursuit of sensory enhancement,

22. Zhang Junfang 張君房 (or Zhang Shentong 張審通) exercised his judgment and ended up with a third ear protruding from his forehead. The third ear was said to be particularly keen of hearing. See *Taiping guangji* 太平廣記 (Taipei: Guxin shuju, 1976), 296.623a.

23. Lu K’uan-yü (Charles Luk), trans., *The Surangama Sutra (Leng Yen Ching)* (London: Rider and Co., 1966), 106. For more on the role of Buddhism in the life and work of Su Shi, see Beata Grant, *Mount Lu Revisited: Buddhism in the Life and Writings of Su Shi* (Honolulu: Univ. of Hawaii Press, 1994).

24. Sturman, “In the Realm of Naturalness,” 177.

Su Shi suggests, is not at all beneficial. In light of the poem's content, it seems more reasonable to think that deafness is not a sign of "political ineptitude," rather it signals a consciously adopted strategy in the face of a threatening political situation. True, Su Shi recognizes that Qin Guan thinks his deafness is a ruse. But instead of denying his friend's claim, Su Shi gives him a strident warning against exercising his judgment in realms beyond his jurisdiction. When Zhang Junfang 張君房 behaved in this manner, he was punished with an ear that grew from his forehead.

If we accept this trope of deafness, then the imagery and colophons of *The Ear Picker* shift in their meaning. With a view that deafness signifies an advantageous state, Su Shi thinks little about cutting off and giving away his ears to Wang Shen. The nature of Wang's deafness, however, remains unexplained. One may only conjecture that his illness involves some circumstance, imagined or otherwise, that prevents him from access to political noise, if the code is to be applied consistently. In his response, Wang corroborates the understanding that deafness, or ignorance of the political ruckus, can have its benefits. He likewise recalls the story of Hundun and the lesson that pursuit of sensory capacities may end in disastrous results. As for the image in *The Ear Picker*, if read as a model to emulate, then the figure's gesture must be read not as an attempt to bore a hole or cure himself but rather as a sign of deafness and pleasant idleness, which indicate remove and unconcern for the world of politics. The interpretation may be bolstered if the viewer interprets the landscape screen, the scrolls, and other objects for amusement on the table as signs of an alternative world with which the ear picker aligns himself.

Wang Shen's penultimate couplet seems to refer to remarks that have been misunderstood, and we may reason that the speaker of those remarks is Su Shi, whose sharp wit led to stinging retribution by his political enemies. Currently among friends, Su Shi's motivation for those remarks finds sympathy, but as time passes, Wang wonders whether there still will be an audience that understands. The situation at the capital, despite the government reversals, still harbors dangers of which both he and Wang are well aware. To soften the pessimistic outlook for how Su Shi will be remembered by future generations, Wang ends his poem on a hopeful note. He may not be referring to secrets among friends or to his secret role as the painter of *The Ear Picker*, but rather to the possibility of a change for the better. Someday, he suggests encouragingly, there will come a change that will usher in a season of renewal. Such a reading of Wang's poem seems consistent with the common use of seasonal metaphors for political shifts and consistent with the tone of Wang's earlier poem quoted by Su Shi. In both cases, Wang resolves an unpleasant and tense situation in the last couplet, sounding an optimistic note.

In the Crow Terrace Poetry Case, one of Su Shi's poems singled out as offensive was originally written as a colophon following a set of paintings depicting imperial horses by the Tang-dynasty court painter, Han Gan 韓幹 (ca. 720–80).<sup>25</sup> At the time, these scrolls were owned by Wang Shen. The example of Su Shi's poem responding to Han Gan's painting of horses raises an alternative explanation for the origin of *The Ear Picker*. Simply because the imagery fits so well with the circumstances in the lives of Northern Song officials who owned and inscribed the painting does not prove that one among them actually painted the work. Prior to Su Shi's poetic colophon, Han Gan's image of imperial horses bore no relation to Northern Song politics. In a similar fashion, *The Ear Picker* may have been transformed from an image innocent of political implications into a vehicle for expressing dissent when Su Shi and Wang Shen added their colophons. At least one work by a Southern Tang painter

25. Hartman, "Poetry and Politics in 1079," 34.

is documented in Wang Shen's collection, and perhaps *The Ear Picker* was another.<sup>26</sup> As Wang Gong prepared to take a new government position, Wang Shen selected *The Ear Picker* from among his collection to give to his friend. Wang Shen may have expected that Wang Gong would request colophons from their common friends, Su Che and Su Shi, and that their writings would include subtle political critique. But according to his colophon, he is altogether surprised by Su Shi's recollection. In other words, Wang Shen professes no anticipation of Su Shi's interpretation of the painting's imagery.

In this scenario, whatever the earlier meaning of *The Ear Picker*, the Northern Song colophon writers chose to identify the ear-picking figure with people and concerns familiar to themselves. The colophons demonstrate that by the late eleventh century, these literati viewers looked to the painting not so much as a window into the art, artists, ideas, or history of the Southern Tang dynasty, but rather as a mirror for seeing their own personal experiences. Any remnant of original meaning, as a result of their colophons, becomes submerged beneath their narratives. Their stories are so compelling that the possibility of Wang Qihan (or another tenth-century painter) as the artist of *The Ear Picker* becomes difficult to conceive. *The Ear Picker* thus represents an occupation or appropriation of possibly earlier idioms to suit the needs and views of Su Che, Su Shi, Wang Shen, and Wang Gong.

#### COMMODITY CONCERNS

For the group of Northern Song viewers the authenticity of *The Ear Picker* mattered little or not at all. The handscroll functioned as a vehicle for their clandestine conversation, and part of its value lay not in its possession but rather in its circulation among friends. During the time when Su Che, Su Shi, and Wang Shen inscribed their colophons, the handscroll was briefly withdrawn from a commodity economy into a limited arena for private consumption. Adopting Igor Kopytoff's language, we may call this process a variant of singularization, when a commodity is removed from circulation and marked personally. The commodity's value is determined less by an impersonal market and more by individual psychology and memory. If the Northern Song writers exemplify this process of singularization, then the next three colophons, by Shi Gongyi 史公奕 (fl. ca. 1210–27), Dong Qichang 董其昌 (1555–1636), and Wen Zhenmeng 文震孟 (1574–1636), written between the years 1210 and 1631, focus on the problems of valuation and possession, problems that are part and parcel of an economy of commodities.

In the first of these colophons, Shi Gongyi recounts wistfully how the painting was once the property of an esteemed family [figure 4]:

Wang Qihan's painting of *The Ear Picker* is something that Mr. Li Shuxia of my hometown collected. Shuxia was a descendant of a famous Song-dynasty minister, [Li] Qingchen. He was poor and had few friends, but his family had many works of calligraphy and painting. During his whole life he was parsimonious, and he was unwilling to show [the art] readily to others. But, not long after [he] died, [the collection] was sold by unworthy descendants. Now I see this [painting], and unaware I sigh and regret all day. So, now we know that through three changes of sons, what generation won't have sons [who depart from his father's ways]? The *gengwu* year of the Da'an reign [1210] the middle of autumn, written by the Daoist of Yuanshan, Shi Gongyi, [zi] Jihongfu.

26. Wang Shen owned a painting of onions painted by Ding Qian and inscribed by the last Southern Tang emperor, Li Yu. Guo Rouxu, *Tuhua jianwenzhi*, rpt. in Alexander C. Soper, *Kuo Jo-hsu's Experiences in Painting: T'u-hua chien-wen chih: An Eleventh Century History of Chinese Painting with the Chinese Text in Facsimile* (Washington, D.C.: American Council of Learned Societies, 1951), 2.24b.

FIG. 4. Colophons by Shi Gongyi, Dong Qichang, and Wen Zhenmeng.

王齊翰畫挑耳，吾鄉李叔夏先生所藏物也。叔夏，宋名卿清臣之後。清苦寡合。其家書畫甚多，平生靳靳不肯容易示人，然而死未久，為不肖子孫所鬻，今觀之，不覺歎惋彌日。乃知三變之子何代無之。大安庚午中秋日，涇山道人史公奕季宏父題。

Shi Gongyi makes no mention of the scroll's imagery or textual accompaniments, and devotes his colophon instead to disapproving of the poor judgment exercised by Li Shuxia's heirs when they sold the handscroll. Little is known about Li Shuxia, whom Shi Gongyi identifies as a fellow townsman, perhaps of Yuanshan; but his ancestor Li Qingchen (fl. ca. 1065–1113) achieved some fame.<sup>27</sup> Qingchen began his political career with some military involvement in the second year of the Yuanfeng reign-era (1080) before quickly advancing in the civil bureaucracy. Four years later he was appointed a Vice-Minister in the Ministry of Personnel 吏部尚書右丞. His official career spanned the late Northern Song period, but he also experienced moments of setback that may have been related to his association with persons in Su Shi's coterie. Frustrated with government service, Qingchen eventually retired and devoted his time to managing his personal library. Due to his close association with persons such as Huang Tingjian 黃庭堅 (1045–1105) and Su Che, Qingchen may have acquired *The Ear Picker*, which Li Shuxia later inherited. Shuxia must have died sometime before 1210, leaving this scroll behind. Although Shi Gongyi laments the actions of Shuxia's heirs, it is only now that the scroll no longer belongs to the family that Shi Gongyi enjoys access to it. That he himself owned the work remains a possibility, but he does not make this point explicit. Perhaps revealing so would make known his culpability in extracting the painting in the face of nobler, filial ideals. From the point of view expressed in his colophon, Shi Gongyi sees material objects, such as the scroll, as signifying by their whereabouts the upholding of family traditions. It appears that economic forces have triumphed over filial piety.

Such economic forces only gained in strength. The late Ming-dynasty period is known for the further development of a market for art and antiquities along with the rise of anxieties related to their possession. The two Ming-dynasty colophons are characteristic. Dong Qichang implicitly raises the delicate question of attribution [figure 4]:

27. I have not found any references for Li Shuxia, but his ancestor, Li Qingchen, is mentioned numerous times in *Songshi*.

The screen painting in *The Ear Picker* does not use texture strokes or dry brushwork. It is a Tang-period “boneless,” colored landscape. Wang Jinqing [Wang Shen] properly imitates this [style]. In my family, we have *Mountains of Immortals* [by Wang Shen], which bears a striking resemblance to this. Written by Dong Qichang.

挑耳圖屏障畫不用皴擦，唐時沒骨設色山也。王晉卿正仿之，予家有仙山圖絕相似。董其昌題。

Focusing on the techniques used to represent the landscape in the screen, Dong is reminded of the style of Wang Shen as manifested in a painting in his own collection. He does not explicitly contradict the traditional attribution to Wang Qihan as avowed by the slender-gold inscription, but limits his assessment to noting a striking resemblance. No doubt the presence of Wang Shen’s colophon would also have been suggestive to Dong.

The next colophon writer, Wen Zhenmeng, leaves evidence of his engagement with the scroll’s image and all of its textual accompaniment [figure 4]:

A painting by Wang Qihan. Song Siling [Gaozong, r. 1127–1162] has written on it. The two Su brothers and Wang Jinqing’s ink [inscriptions] are marvellous. I am not a connoisseur, and I dare not force explanatory comments of their words. [I can] only [say] that this scroll is in the collection of the An family of Xishan. In the decades between [An] Guipo and [An] Wujiu, the work was obtained and then lost, lost and then regained. It seems to be protected by spirits. Surely, [it] is a treasure. It was circulated, displayed, recorded, and handed down, and was especially difficult for [An] Wujiu to regain. Moreover, [this phenomenon] completely erases the sighs of the Yuan-shan Daoist [Shi Gongyi]. The *xinwei* year of the Chongzhen reign era [1631], early spring. Written below Juhua. Wen Zhenmeng.

王齊翰畫，宋思陵題，二蘇及王晉卿墨妙，余非鑑賞家不敢強作解事語也，惟是此卷為錫山安氏家藏，自桂坡翁以及無咎數十年來得而失，失而復得。類若有神物護持之，洵為珍物矣。轉展錄傳，無咎復之尤艱，更一洗涸山道人之歎。崇禎辛未小春題于菊華下。文震孟。

Although he names the Southern Song emperor, Gaozong 高宗 (r. 1127–1162), Wen must be referring to the imitations of the calligraphic style of Gaozong’s predecessor, Emperor Huizong. Wen also mentions colophons by the Su brothers (Su Che and Su Shi) and Wang Shen, though he declines to respond to their texts. More than explicating the painting or the colophons by the famous Northern Song literati, Wen is interested in relating the situation of the painting as material possession belonging to two members of the An family of Xishan, An Guo 安國 (Guipo 桂坡, 1481–1534) and An Wujiu.<sup>28</sup> An Guo acquired the painting but later lost it. Only several decades later was An Wujiu able to reacquire it. Instead of explaining the mundane circumstances that probably led to the acquisition, loss, and reacquisition of the painting, Wen prefers to think that the painting is “protected by spirits,” who secured the happy return of the scroll to the An family. Some four centuries after Shi Gongyi lamented the implicit sale of *The Ear Picker* by descendants with different priorities, Wen offers this exemplary story to “completely erase the sighs of the Yuanshan Daoist [Shi Gongyi].”

The accelerated speed with which material objects circulated in the Ming dynasty along with the possibility that two or more versions of *The Ear Picker* were in existence give rise to the kinds of interpretations and narratives generated by viewers.<sup>29</sup> On the one hand,

28. Chang Bide, *Mingren zhuanji ziliao suoyin* (Taipei: National Central Library, 1966), 119.

29. One extant, later copy of *The Ear Picker* has been dated to the Ming dynasty. Reproductions may be found in Wu, *The Double Screen*, fig. 116, and Lawton, *Chinese Figure Painting*, 78.



FIG. 5. Colophons by Yongcheng, Yongqi, and Yongrong.

audiences expressed a concern for authorship; on the other hand, ownership and provenance come to the fore.<sup>30</sup> For Wen Zhenmeng, *The Ear Picker* offered a space for him to engage in a conversation with Shi Gongyi across time. While not a conversation in which all parties are physically present and responsive, nevertheless Wen Zhenmeng and Shi Gongyi left statements assuming that future audiences would read and respond to them.

ENTANGLEMENT AND ENLIGHTENMENT:  
COLOPHONS FROM THE QIANLONG PERIOD

Entanglement in connoisseurial questions and enlightenment are two themes expressed in the colophons of thirteen viewers writing in the mid- to late eighteenth century. At this time, *The Ear Picker* appears to have been the property of one of the Qianlong 乾隆 emperor's (r. 1736–95) grandsons, Miande 綿德, who signs his colophon with the name Shufang 淑芳. Although his is not the first of this series of colophons, a couplet from his text exerts a sense of ownership over the scroll [figure 5]:

我生聒聒愧書涇    My life is muddled and I am ashamed of my obsession with texts,  
持此發蒙勘省記    But holding this [scroll] inspires me to record my reflections.

No other colophon writer draws attention to the physical manipulation of the painting, so when Miande describes his action of “holding this [scroll],” it suggests that he enjoys a privileged relationship that allows him to handle the art object at will.

The current order of the Qing-period colophons suggests that Miande chose to observe social hierarchies that grant priority to elders and those of higher rank. Accordingly, we first encounter a text by Yongcheng 永城, who signs as “the fourth son of the emperor.” Although dated slightly earlier, the following colophon is by Yongqi 永琪, “the fifth son of the emperor.” Next we encounter a colophon by Yongrong 永瑤, the sixth son, followed by those

30. Craig Clunas has explored the anxiety about objects expressed in texts during the middle to late Ming period. See his *Superfluous Things: Material Culture and Social Status in Early Modern China* (Urbana: Univ. of Illinois Press, 1991).



FIG. 6. Colophons by Miande, Mian'en, and Guanbao.

of Miande and Mian'en 綿恩, who both belong to the next generation. Only after colophons by members of the imperial family are those by nine officials and scholars appended. In the order of their colophons, they are Guanbo 觀保 (*jinshi* 1737, d. 1774), Xie Yong 謝墉 (1719–95, *jinshi* 1752), Zhang Taikai 張泰開 (*jinshi* 1742, ca. 1688–1774), Jin Shen 金甦 (d. 1782), Lu Wenchao 盧文弨, Liu Xingwei 劉星煒 (*jinshi* 1748), Wang Tingyu 汪廷璵, Li Zongjian 李中簡 (*jinshi* 1748), and Wang Yongxi 汪永錫 (*jinshi* 1754). None of the officials' colophons are dated, but they were probably written between 1765, the date given by Yongcheng and Yongqi, and 1774, the year of Guanbao's death. Given the common allusions and ideas in these colophons, moreover, it seems possible that at least some were written during occasions in which two or more people viewed the scroll together. In addition, the arrangement of most of the eighteenth-century colophons supports the argument that the writing was done in the company of others. For example, the two colophons by Miande and Mian'en are located above and beneath each other, suggesting that they planned their location and layout, and the next three colophons by Guanbao, Xie Yong, and Zhang Taikai respond spatially to this arrangement [figure 6]. Perhaps Miande hosted a literary gathering to view and discuss works of art, such as *The Ear Picker*.<sup>31</sup> Given the capital appointments of all or most of the men involved, it would have been possible for Miande, Mian'en, and the nine officials to gather together to view the painting and write colophons.

Two common themes arise from reading the fourteen colophons. The first theme returns to connoisseurial concerns; the second focuses on a discussion of the senses, especially aural, and their associations. Interestingly, these colophons add to the allusions and ideas first voiced in the texts by Su Shi and Wang Shen nearly seven hundred years earlier.

31. The colophons by princes Yongcheng, Yongqi, and Yongrong are written on separate sheets, suggesting that had they attended such a gathering, they must have chosen to delay writing their colophons.

FIG. 7. Colophons by Zhang Taikai, Xie Yong, and Jin Shen.

Concerns about the painting’s attribution continued to have currency, as attested in the colophons by Yongcheng, Yongqi, and Yongrong. Their privileged access to the imperial collection may have given them an advantage in distinguishing between authentic and fake artworks. Yongcheng reasons that [figure 5]:

|         |                                                                       |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 戲謔元如屬晉卿 | Playing and joking are characteristic of [Wang] Jingqing,             |
| 描摸任遣充齊翰 | This painting pretends to be by [Wang] Qihan.                         |
| 命名遑論是耶非 | Giving it [this] attribution is hurried and incorrect,                |
| 標題頓自宣和換 | The label was changed beginning in the Xuanhe [period]. <sup>32</sup> |

Finding the Xuanhe-period markings unconvincing and aware of Wang Shen’s humorous predilections, Yongcheng argues that *The Ear Picker* ought to be the work of Wang Shen and not Wang Qihan.<sup>33</sup> Yongcheng’s brothers, Yongqi and Yongrong, also express interest in the problem of authenticity. Yongqi writes, in part [figure 4]:

|         |                                                                                      |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 挑耳圖工妙難擬 | <i>The Ear Picker</i> ’s craftsmanship is marvelous and difficult to compare,        |
| 斐然古色霜縑里 | Marvelous is the ancient color, and the silk has a frost[y patina].                  |
| 底須真贋互雌黃 | To decide whether it is authentic or fake, one must thoroughly evaluate its quality, |
| 睿思寶墨宣和璽 | There is the emperor’s precious ink and a Xuanhe imperial seal.                      |

32. For complete transcriptions and translations of this and all colophons on *The Ear Picker*, see De-nin D. Lee, 262–73.

33. The submerged or proto-narrative underlying Yongcheng’s reasoning—something motivates Wang Shen to materialize his penchant for jesting with his friends by means of painting and gifting the resulting artwork—is more fully explored in Sturman, “In the Realm of Naturalness,” 175–77.

FIG. 8. Colophons by Lu Wenchao, Liu Xingwei, and Wang Tingyu.

Compared to Yongcheng, he is more equivocal, directing his reader to consider the quality of the painting, the visibly old silk, as well as the calligraphy and seal of the Song emperor, Huizong. In referring to the latter, he expresses respect with the phrase, “precious ink,” conveying more confidence in the authenticity of the calligraphy. Youngest of the three imperial sons, Yongrong likewise leaves the issue of authenticity unresolved [figure 5]:

|       |                                                              |
|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| 讀畫觸遐思 | Looking at this painting connects to thoughts from long ago, |
| 肖物有妙腕 | Things portrayed have a marvellous touch [lit., wrist].      |
| 添豪豈易工 | The brushwork is surely not easily done,                     |
| 還擬詢齊翰 | Go back and ask [Wang] Qihan.                                |

Instead of making a judgment, Yongrong suggests that the reader go back in time and put the question to the (possible) artist himself.

When Yongcheng, Yongqi, and Yongrong look at *The Ear Picker* through the lens of connoisseurship, the painting functions not as a meaning-bearing image but an artifact whose origins need to be located in time and associated with a specific artist. In attempting to make an attribution, the princes bring to bear not only the quality of the painting and the silk which may provide clues for the object’s age but also the texts accumulated on the scroll. These texts include earlier judgments by respected experts, in this case Dong Qichang and the imperial authority projected by the slender-gold style inscription. But the colophons by the Northern Song viewers make an impact, too. The wittiness of Wang Shen, Yongcheng considers, makes him the likely artist of the painting.

The Northern Song colophons also lay the basis for another discussion concerning the senses, among which hearing figures prominently. The Qing-dynasty writers incorporate a number of allusions into their texts, resulting in an eclectic accumulation of literary, historical, and philosophical associations with ear problems ranging from deafness to overly sensitive hearing. The senses more generally can also overwhelm, mislead, and cause a

FIG. 9. Colophons by Li Zhongjian and Wang Yongxi.

person to feel desires within and toward the material world. In this manner, the senses constitute an impediment to detachment from the world, or to enlightenment. The general situation discussed in these colophons is not unlike the ideas Su Shi expressed in his poem to Qin Guan. In turn, both the colophons and Su Shi's poem raise issues that are reminiscent of the Buddha's advice to Ananda as recorded in the apocryphal *Surangama Sutra*. Studied by Su Shi, this sutra enjoyed another moment of popularity during the Qianlong era when the emperor sponsored its translation into the Mongolian, Manchu, and Tibetan languages.<sup>34</sup> The sutra focuses on a discussion of the senses that mislead and impede Ananda and others from achieving enlightenment. Yet paradoxically, the senses are also what make following the path to enlightenment possible, and several bodhisattvas discuss how different sensory capacities aided their enlightenment. The key, the Buddha preaches, is to "turn the organ of sight [or sound, etc.] back to its source."<sup>35</sup> Colophon writers make a similar suggestion when they promote the use of *The Ear Picker* as an object for reflecting on the senses.

In their consideration of the meanings of *The Ear Picker* and the colophons by Su Shi and Wang Shen, the Qing-dynasty colophon writers draw on a wide variety of texts. Yongcheng even states that he has consulted the *Dongpu zhilin* 東坡志林, and perhaps he

34. The production of the new edition required eleven years of work on the part of scholars and translators, and it was finally issued in 1763. See Baron A. von Staël-Holstein, "The Emperor Ch'ien-lung and the Larger *Suram-gamasutra*," *Harvard Journal of Asiatic Studies* 1.1 (1936): 136–46. I am grateful to Pat Berger who first pointed out this source to me.

35. Lu, *Surangama Sutra*, 124.

(and others) read and remembered Su Shi's poem to Qin Guan when composing their poetic colophons. A number of allusions common to Su Shi's work and the eighteenth-century colophons suggest that, at the very least, all these viewers shared and participated in a single literary tradition. No less than five, and possibly seven, writers as well as Su Shi refer to the story of Yin Zhongkan's father.<sup>36</sup> He claimed to hear the din of bulls fighting, but after an investigation into his malady, it became apparent that the noise was only the sound of ants moving beneath his bed. This gentleman's problem may be contrasted with that of Xue Junzhou 薛君胄 who evidently heard the sounds of carts and horses after he had become drunk.<sup>37</sup> Diminutive servants in charge of tiny carts soon emerged from his ears and informed him that they were from the state of Douyuan 兜元國, located inside his ear. This story is mentioned by four writers, Yongcheng, Miande, Xie Yong, and Jin Shen. Of all the writers, Yongqi exhibits a particular interest in cures or solutions to ear and other problems. Like Su Shi and Wang Shen before him, Yongqi alludes to the story of Hundun, who forfeited his life when his friends Whish and Whoosh tried to create sensory capacities for him. As a contrast to this failure, Yongqi reminds his reader of the story of carpenter Shi and the gentleman from Ying.<sup>38</sup> The latter had a bit of plaster stuck at the end of his nose; Carpenter Shi skillfully cut off the plaster without doing any harm to the nose.

In considering the maladies and the solutions of these literary examples, the Qing writers offer comparisons to the sudden bout of deafness suffered by Wang Shen and the shocking but effective solution given by Su Shi. Wang Shen's problem, they imply, is all in his head. At least in the case of Xue Junzhou, the sounds were literally emanating from inside his head. Su Shi's solution is unorthodox, but commendable. Yongqi, for example, writes [figure 4]:

|           |                                                                                            |
|-----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 那將搔背倩仙姑   | Who will scratch one's back, ask a female immortal.                                        |
| 定知斲鼻煩鄧士   | It's certain that had his nose been cut, the gentleman from Ying would have been troubled. |
| 東坡禪悅雜談諧   | [Su] Dongpo meditated and awoke to a mixture of humor,                                     |
| 重聽虛中霍然已   | [He] listened again amidst the void, which suddenly ceased.                                |
| 君不聞       | Sir, haven't you heard?                                                                    |
| 儵忽七日經營渾沌死 | Whish and Whoosh operated for seven days, and Hundun died;                                 |
| 社酒治聾真可鄙   | Abstaining from wine to cure deafness is really too much.                                  |

Like having an immortal scratch one's back or Carpenter Shi slice plaster off the nose, Su Shi's response to Wang Shen's deafness was skilled and enlightened. He must have meditated and learned from others' past mistakes, that is, the overzealous efforts of Whish and Whoosh, before embarking on the appropriate cure for his friend. In another case, Su Shi's method is likened to Chan techniques for inciting enlightenment: Li Zhongjian writes, "Old Po's teaching is a rousing cudgel" 老坡學棒喝 [figure 9].<sup>39</sup>

While Qing-dynasty viewers perceive Su Shi as an instrument of enlightenment, they associate deafness, at times, with the mundane world. Yongrong exhorts [figure 5]:

36. This story from the *Shishuo xinyu* 世說新語 is mentioned by Yongcheng, Yongrong, Mian'en, Xie Yong, Wang Tingyu, and may be the source of the variants "moving gnats" by Lu Wenchao and "fighting insects" by Li Zhongjian. See Lee, 264–72.

37. See Niu Sengru 牛僧孺 (779–849), *Xuanguai lu* 玄怪錄 (*Tang Wudai biji xiaoshuo daguan* 唐五代筆記小說大觀 [Shanghai: Shanghai guji, 2000]), 3.383–85.

38. Watson, *Chuang Tzu*, 269.

39. Lee, 272.

|       |                                                           |
|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| 要洗萬古聾 | One must wash away ages-old deafness                      |
| 一朝得泮奐 | And in one morning achieve complete purity.               |
| 癢癢心自知 | The itchiness though hidden, one knows it in one's heart, |
| 嗒然坐清晏 | Serenely, meditate quietly.                               |

His advice to meditate follows provocative comments, “Looking at this screen of a person picking his ear, / [I see that] the root of the dusty world can be severed.” Focusing on the subject and content of the image, he perceived the ear picker as someone who has successfully detached himself from worldly matters.

A pair of couplets from Miande's colophon echoes these ideas as he outlines some aspects of the relationship between the viewer, the scroll, and Buddhist practice. He writes [figure 6]:

|         |                                                                               |
|---------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 聲聞辟支微妙諦 | In sounds the pratyekabuddha's quiet mysterious truth is heard, <sup>40</sup> |
| 丹青畫出思聰意 | In red and blue, the painting expresses the clear meaning of thoughts.        |
| ...     | ...                                                                           |
| 我生瞶瞶愧書淫 | My life is muddled and I am ashamed of my obsession with texts,               |
| 持此發蒙勘省記 | But holding this [scroll] inspires me to record my reflections.               |

Miande begins his colophon with the idea that there are sounds, however quiet, that may be heard. These sounds, he asserts, are the Buddha's truth. This truth, although carried in sound, may be perceived clearly in the visual medium of the painting. The idea that the painting may be a vehicle for enlightenment is reiterated in his closing couplet. Although the confession may have its perfunctory aspect as Miande admits to an attachment to worldly things such as books, which causes his life to be “muddled,” yet, among his material possessions there is still something that may be used to assist him in reaching enlightenment, this handscroll painting.

Using *The Ear Picker* as an object for reflection and aid toward enlightenment may be a view that others shared. For example, when Xie Yong considers the cures for deafness, he recalls a remedy cited in unnamed textual sources [figure 7].

|       |                                          |
|-------|------------------------------------------|
| 即聾亦多門 | So, deafness has many gates              |
| 不在兜元國 | But not in the state of Douyuan.         |
| 治之有神方 | To treat it there is a magical way       |
| 經籍畫藥石 | The classics have paintings of medicines |
| 遠勝文蓋草 | Much more effective than artemisia       |
| 開通聾與聵 | For opening the deaf and earless.        |

In contrast to the opinions of Yongqi or Li Zhongjian, the solution is not Su Shi's shocking threat of cutting off his own ears but an image of medicine. Xie Yong claims that the “paintings of medicines” are “much more effective than artemisia for opening the deaf and earless.” The implication of Xie Yong's view is that the painting of *The Ear Picker* itself may have curative properties as well.

Of the maladies *The Ear Picker* may assist in healing, foremost is of course deafness. But as other colophons of this period also suggest, deafness may be a metaphor for an unenlightened state. More broadly construed, the problem arises from all the senses, causing impediments to disengagement from the world. Zhang Taikai defines the problem with reference to the *Daodejing* [figure 7].

40. A pratyekabuddha is a being who, like an arhat, has achieved enlightenment. Unlike a bodhisattva, however, a pratyekabuddha does not vow to aid other sentient beings towards achieving enlightenment.



|       |                                                         |
|-------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| 五色能迷目 | The five colors blind our eyes,                         |
| 五聲能聾耳 | The five notes deafen our ears. <sup>41</sup>           |
| 晉卿聲色侈 | Jinjing's [Wang Shen's] notes and colors are excessive, |
| 致疾無乃是 | The cause of illness is none other than this.           |

The eyes and ears, Zhang observes, can be misled by over-stimulation. In the case of Wang Shen, whom he believes to be author of both poems and painting, sounds and colors have become extreme and resulted in sickness.

At the same time, deafness may also be construed as a condition of release, in contrast to suffering the din of “bulls fighting.” Lu Wenchao writes [figure 8]:

|         |                                                                           |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 物莫兩大甘長聾 | Those without these two great [ears] enjoy a deafness, sweet and long:    |
| 端精幾欲塞兩豆 | One wants to stuff two peas at either end.                                |
| 尚恐行蠓聲彫鴻 | Not startled by marching gnats, though the sound is disorderly and great, |
| 胡為挾摘不宜止 | Why pick instead of simply ceasing [to listen]?                           |

Would it not be better to stuff two peas into one's ears than to pick them open and suffer unceasingly, he asks rhetorically. Xie Yong would agree. He writes [figure 7]:

|       |                                                      |
|-------|------------------------------------------------------|
| 不聞名曰希 | That which is not heard, is called “rarefied”;       |
| 至道歸藏密 | The utmost Dao is to store away the secret.          |
| 更息文字詮 | Even more should we cease explaining in words,       |
| 以降煩惱賊 | So as to decrease the bothersome and vexing thieves. |
| 勘書書義蒙 | In collating texts, the texts' meaning is hidden;    |
| 挑耳耳根汨 | In picking ears, the ears' roots are destroyed.      |

To be deaf, Xie asserts, is to have hope. In a state of not hearing, one can follow the Dao and reap its benefits. Words only get in the way and rob one of the possibility of achieving enlightenment. On a pessimistic note, he concludes that the process of collating, as suggested by the painting's title, buries the meaning of texts; so also is the process of picking one's ears destructive. By opening the ears, one may destroy the organ altogether (as in the case of Hundun), and lose the possibility of hearing and achieving enlightenment. This view that deafness has its advantages echoes the sentiments expressed earlier by Wang Shen in his poetic reply to Su Shi and by Su Shi in his poem to Qin Guan. While it makes more sense to understand the earlier discussions as focused on specific political events and their authors' desires to distance themselves from the political realm, the eighteenth-century discussion reveals a distinctly Buddhist strain and considers more broadly the role played by the senses in both impeding and advancing one's path toward enlightenment, or the detachment from sensory and worldly desires.

Eighteenth-century colophon writers demonstrate clearly a concern with the imagery and attribution of *The Ear Picker* as well as the meanings of the Northern Song colophons, especially those by Su Shi and Wang Shen. They introduce at least one new way of interpreting *The Ear Picker* that concerns the relationship of the senses to the process of enlightenment,

41. Philip J. Ivanhoe, *The Daodejing of Laozi* (New York: Seven Bridges, 2002), 12. Coincidentally, Su Shi himself used the same quotation from the *Daodejing* in his 1077 essay commemorating the Pavilion of Treasured Painting built to house Wang Shen's collection. The thrust of this essay was to urge Wang Shen not to develop an overly strong, and therefore debilitating, attachment to material things. “If one lets one's thoughts dwell with things, even a trifle will suffice to give joy, while even a great thing will not be enough to cause sorrow. If one lets one's thoughts be detained by things, even a trifle will suffice to cause sorrow, while even a great thing will not be enough to give joy.” See R. H. van Gulik, *Chinese Pictorial Art as Viewed by the Connoisseur* (Rome: Istituto italiano per il Medio ed Estremo Oriente, 1958), 508.

a theme that is simultaneously being discussed as the Qianlong emperor sponsors a new, quadrilingual edition of the *Surangama Sutra*.

The connection between imagery and the idea of enlightenment is not necessarily made directly or immediately. Rather, it is reached gradually through the series of colophons, as writers focus on slightly different issues and extend the discourse in various directions. The two themes independent of each other, connoisseurial issues and the relationship between the senses and enlightenment, could actually be intertwined. Several imperial sons raised the issue of connoisseurship, questioning the identity of the artist responsible for the image. For example, Yongcheng claims that connoisseurial judgment depends on the eyes: “Who can determine the authenticity of paintings? / *The Ear Picker* has circulated and delighted many eyes” 畫圖真偽誰能辨，挑耳流傳供目玩。He later asserts that “*The Ear Picker* requires attentive eyes and attentive ears.” Here, he yokes two sensory apparatuses, the eyes (necessary for connoisseurial evaluation) and the ears (the subject of earlier colophons and one element in the painting’s imagery).

The senses are necessary if one is to exercise connoisseurship, but the senses may fail. When Yongqi engages the issue of connoisseurship, he declines to make a judgment, advising instead that one should “go back and ask [Wang] Qihan.” His eyes are insufficient for making an unimpeachable determination. That the senses are subject to limitations and may prove unreliable is made clear through the many allusions to aural problems. Certainly, Wang Shen provided the source for eighteenth-century viewers by referring to the story of Hundun, for whom supposed improvement turned tragic. The colophon writers may also have known of Su Shi’s poem to Qin Guan, which is replete with allusions, including those to Hundun, Yin Zhongkan’s father, and Zhang Junfang. Moreover, Su Shi likens the senses to thieves, a comparison that is also made in the *Surangama Sutra*. These allusions recur in the Qing dynasty colophons while new ones are introduced. While the variety of references demonstrates the writers’ literary breadth, the effect is to expand the horizon of meanings and interpretations for *The Ear Picker*.

Problems with the ears, both deafness and overly sensitive hearing, signify in the Qing period colophons a state of non-enlightenment. Realizing that his sensory attachment to worldly things is an impediment to enlightenment, Miande writes defensively. He asks rhetorically, “If you flee vulgarity, how can you ask about matters of the world?” 避俗安能請世事。Fortunately for him, he need not dispense with his worldly possessions, including *The Ear Picker*. Xie Yong, for one, offers helpfully, “Display the painting to obtain good admonitions. / Open the scroll and trust there is benefit” 展畫得良箴，開卷信有益。The optimism and practicality conveyed here are not unlike the Buddha’s instructions to his follower Ananda. Despite the fact that the senses are primary culprits in preventing enlightenment, the Buddha and bodhisattvas explain that, on the contrary, the senses may be helpful. In the middle of the dialogue, the Buddha opens the forum to the bodhisattvas and asks them to share their experiences of reaching enlightenment. Specifically, he wants them to discuss the sensory organ that helped them to attain enlightenment. Guanyin argues for the primacy of hearing in that process. He states, “. . . I developed the Bodhi Mind and, for my entry into Samadhi, I was instructed by [the Buddha] to practise meditation by means of the organ of hearing. At first by directing the organ of hearing into the stream of meditation, this organ was detached from its object, and by wiping out (the concept of) both sound and stream-entry, both disturbance and stillness became clearly non-existent. Thus advancing step by step both hearing and its object ceased completely. . . .”<sup>42</sup> Following Guanyin’s testimony,

42. Lu, *Surangama Sutra*, 135.

Manjusri offers a *gatha* confirming the primacy of hearing as the most appropriate channel by which to gain enlightenment. Manjusri states, in part:

I now submit to the World Honoured One  
 That all Buddhas in this world appear  
 To teach the most appropriate method  
 Which consists in using pervasive sound.  
 The state of Samadhi can be realized by means of hearing.  
 Thus was Avalokitesvara freed from suffering  
 . . .  
 But if you cannot eradicate  
 Desire, to hear much causes errors.  
 To hear your very Self, why not turn backward  
 That faculty employed to hear Buddha's words?  
 Hearing is not of itself,  
 But owes its name to sound.  
 Freed from sound by turning hearing backwards,  
 What do you call that which is disengaged?  
 When one sense organ has to its source returned,  
 All the six senses thereby are liberated.<sup>43</sup>

In other instances, the Buddha exhorts Ananda to turn his sight back on itself as a means to reflect on that sense and to free himself from its hold. The same advice is repeated with respect to the other senses. With the *Surangama Sutra*'s prescription in mind, the logic of using *The Ear Picker* as a meditative tool for attaining enlightenment becomes clearer.

In summary, the process of viewing *The Ear Picker* and exercising one's visual faculties leads viewers of the Qing dynasty to a realization of sensory limitations in making connoisseurial assessments. Already, they feel a heightened awareness of straining the eyes, like "turning the sense back upon itself." The actions of the ear picker and the content of the earlier colophons entreat these viewers to recall instances of ear maladies, their cures, and their significance. Miande, for one, confesses remorse for his worldly attachments, but enjoys some consolation by viewing the painting in a manner promoted by the *Surangama Sutra* as a meditative aid.

#### CONCLUSION: THE END OF COLOPHONS

After the spate of new inscriptions in or around 1765, little is known regarding the whereabouts and reception of *The Ear Picker* until the late nineteenth century. In 1871 Li Zuoxian 李左賢 (*jinshi* 1835) records that a certain Ye Zhishen of Hanyang 漢陽 currently owns the work.<sup>44</sup> How the painting left the imperial household and came into Ye's possession is not clear.<sup>45</sup> But possibly prior to Ye's acquisition of it, Geng Zhaozhong 耿昭忠, a Qing

43. Ibid., 146, 148.

44. Li Zuoxian, *Shuhua jianying* 書畫鑑影, 1.23b–27b.

45. Thomas Lawton notes that the imperial art collection suffered major losses following the British and French joint expeditionary force's storming of the Yuanmingyuan in 1860 and the Boxer Rebellion of 1900. In addition, Lawton records the observations of Miao Quansun (1844–1919), a bibliographer who worked on Duanfang's collection of calligraphy and painting, who described how "large numbers of calligraphy works and paintings . . . came onto the antique market in China during the troubled years of the Hsien-feng (1851–61) and T'ung-chih (1862–74) periods, when Tuan-fang profited from the availability of those treasures and assembled a truly remarkable collection." See Lawton, "A Time of Transition: Tuan-fang, 1861–1991," in *A Time of Transition: Two Collectors of Chinese Art* (Lawrence: Spencer Museum of Art, Univ. of Kansas, 1991), 5–64.

bureaucrat, and members of his family impressed about a dozen seals, suggesting that they were prior collectors.<sup>46</sup> By 1909, *The Ear Picker* was certainly in the collection of the Manchu official and art lover, Duanfang 端方.<sup>47</sup> Duanfang must have shown the painting to a number of officials and foreigners in the last years of the Qing dynasty. Evidence of these viewings remains in short inscriptions at the very end of the handscroll. The earliest of these inscriptions was written by Chen Baochen 陳寶琛 in 1908, and the latest by Huang Yilin 黃以霖 who viewed the scroll in 1911, the year of Duanfang's death and the fall of the Qing dynasty. From Duanfang, *The Ear Picker* passed into the hands of his friend, John C. Ferguson.<sup>48</sup> The last private individual to own the scroll, Ferguson gave the work, as mentioned above, along with over a thousand other items from his personal art collection, to Nanjing University in 1934.<sup>49</sup>

Now available primarily through reproductions, *The Ear Picker* may be studied, scrutinized, interpreted, and reinterpreted as part of an ongoing art historical project. It does not circulate physically, nor do new owners and viewers add colophons or seals. But the image and some of its more famous textual additions circulate virtually, and the interaction between object and audience continues to produce new narratives explaining the imagery, especially the action of ear-picking and its possible relationship to the landscape screen and, to a lesser degree, other items represented in the picture.

Under the auspices of Ferguson and then of Nanjing University, *The Ear Picker* reached a far more extensive audience than during the preceding centuries when it circulated among individual and elite owners who showed the scroll only to small groups of friends and colleagues. With modern means of photographic reproduction available, Ferguson publicized the painting and its more famous, early colophons to a wider, English-speaking public. This new public brought a new set of concerns to the evaluation and interpretation of the painting. Ferguson opined confidently, "Considering the full details as to historical ownership, Song dynasty imperial seals, Song dynasty annotations, annotations by two of the most famous calligraphists, Su Shi and Dong Qichang, and its present state of preservation, this scroll is probably the most complete and perfect specimen of early Chinese paintings in any collection."<sup>50</sup> This evaluative treatment, including the use of the word *specimen*, suggests a subject-object relationship between viewer and artwork as well as the creation of an abstract category in which *The Ear Picker* represents a near ideal, neither of which figured so prominently in earlier interactions.

New, too, is a slightly later attempt to politicize the story of the scroll's circulation, in order to echo the Marxist-Maoist view of history as a progression from capitalism to communism. That *The Ear Picker* has been wrested from the hands of rulers, landlords, and capitalists and is now made available to a public including laborers, farmers, teachers, students, and workers—the scroll's rightful owners—is trumpeted as a sign of revolutionary

46. Huang Yuyu counts at least twelve seals, but does not list them; "Wang Qihan hui Tiao'er tu shoucang shimo kao," 51. Li Zuoxian's record seems to be complete, but it lacks the *Qinxi gong houren* 勤僖公侯人 seal that Huang identifies as belonging to Geng Zhaozhong's descendants. See Li Zuoxian, *Shuhua jianying*, 1.23b–27b.

47. Li Baoxun 李葆恂, *Wuyu youyi zhai dushu shi* 無益有益齋讀書史, 1.4a. For more on Duanfang, see Lawton, "A Time of Transition," 5–64.

48. Thomas Lawton, "A Time of Transition: John C. Ferguson, 1866–1945," in *A Time of Transition: Two Collectors of Chinese Art*, 64–104.

49. *Ibid.*, 95.

50. Ferguson, *Chinese Painting* (Chicago: Univ. of Chicago Press, 1927), 82–84.

success.<sup>51</sup> In both cases, the scroll is embedded in new contexts, art-historical and socio-historical, and the textual accompaniment figures prominently in assessing its significance. The gentleman picking his ear and the meaning of this gesture seemed to be of secondary importance until more recently.

In addition to Peter Sturman's discussion of the problem of figure painting in the Northern Song period and the solution represented by the ear picker, Wu Hung has offered a number of alternative scenarios.<sup>52</sup> Locating the scroll within the history of screen painting, Wu argues that the composition uses the landscape screen to signify the "inner realm" of a gentleman or scholar. This inner realm opposes the outer world, the location of Confucian obligations and mundane affairs. It may also be possible that the screen along with the various items displayed on the long, low table symbolizes "refined intellectual activities," thereby contributing to the characterization of the scholar. In other words, they constitute attributes. Still, the landscape may "reflect the scholar's mind" not in a metaphorical way, but it may literally show the sights and environs of his wandering daydream. In a straightforwardly narrative manner, the screen may depict the scholar's villa or retreat to which he is about to depart. Items are readied and placed on the table, and his servant comes to report. Finally, Wu considers the possibility that the ear-picking figure "has reached enlightenment."<sup>53</sup> "[T]his highest stage of spiritual cultivation," he argues, "is indicated by metaphors—the spring willow trees painted on the screen." Never in any of these possibilities he raises does Wu identify the scholar. These numerous possibilities are not all mutually exclusive, but without textual sources or comparative works to conform or deny these interpretations, they cannot be developed further into a convincing argument for the painting's original, specific meaning. Without more information, the painting remains an example of a compositional or pictorial strategy that uses the landscape screen to present an alternate realm.

Both Peter Sturman and Wu Hung have as their project, or as part of his project in the latter instance, the reconstruction of an original meaning. Such a project is especially difficult given the paucity of early documentation. Up until this point, we have avoided a discussion of the painting's original meaning. In conclusion, we might entertain the possibility that the figure represents the legendary hermit Xu You, who cleaned his ears in the river after Yao offered to relinquish the throne to him. One cowherd believed Xu's action polluted the river and hence moved his animals upriver. Xu You became an occasional subject of painting by the Six Dynasties period, and among his later champions was the fifth-century landscape painter and theorist Zong Bing 宗炳.<sup>54</sup> Why a Southern Tang artist should depict such a subject cannot as yet be known, but it seems fairly certain that Wang Qihan did represent figures cleaning their ears.<sup>55</sup> Perhaps *The Ear Picker* might be a kind of imaginary self-portrait or self-projection on the part of Wang Qihan. Early texts have noted that he came from an elite family, and perhaps he was not entirely comfortable with the position of court painter.<sup>56</sup> Thus, the ideas of Zong Bing and the model of Xu You may have held a certain

51. As by Huang Yuyu in the article cited in n. 5 above.

52. Wu, *Double Screen*, 134–99, esp. 144–49.

53. *Ibid.*, 148.

54. William R. B. Acker, *Some T'ang and Pre-T'ang Texts on Chinese Painting*, vol. 2 (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1974), 91, 92 n5, 116, and 119–20 n16.

55. Zhao Mengfu purportedly collected Wang Qihan's *Monk in a Mountain Abode*, depicting a monk cleaning his ear. See Zhou Mi, *Yunyan guoyan lu*, juan 3, excerpted in *Song Liao Jin huajia shiliao*, ed. Chen Gaohua (Beijing: Wenwu, 1984), 38.

56. SCMHP 1.7a/b; THJWZ, 3.13a/b, XHHP, 4.88–89.

appeal. We could continue to build and expand such an interpretation, but the evidence likely would be inconclusive. After all, if the painting did represent Xu You, already by the Northern Song period the importance of the subject matter made no impact on viewers. Nor has any viewer mentioned or made an allusion to Xu You, even though numerous other “ear” stories are named. What this consideration should suggest is that original meanings are elusive and in some instances, as Wang Shen might say, they “leave no traces.” We might lament the loss of *The Ear Picker*’s original meaning, but in its place, an array of other narratives have taken root as viewers attempted to make sense of the image and its many textual accretions. At times, colophons by remarkable and famous men have overshadowed the imagery of the relatively obscure Wang Qihan, whose status as the painting’s creator is far from secure. But a broader view such as that offered by means of cultural biography sheds light on the many other interpretive possibilities that viewers have articulated.